THIRD ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

SCHOONEVELD



Date June 7 and 14, 1673
Forces English: 54 ships; French: 27 ships; Dutch: 55 ships
Losses English and French: 2 ships; Dutch: 1 ship

Location Off the Scheldt estuary

In 1673 the French army was invading the Dutch Republic. The English intended to land troops to support the French, but first needed to defeat de Ruyter or blockade him in port. In May, the Dutch moored in the Schooneveld, an anchorage protected by shoals. Prince Rupert led an Anglo-French fleet to confront them but did not dare take his ships into the narrow channels.

On June 7 de Ruyter surprised the allies by coming out to fight against the odds. Seizing the weather gage, he broke up the French formation in the allied center and then turned to support Admiral Cornelis Tromp's squadron hard-pressed by Rupert. At nightfall the allies were happy to disengage. De Ruyter made a second sortie a week later, once again surprising the allies who had believed the Dutch fleet to be badly mauled. By the end of the second engagement the allies were in no condition to continue at sea and returned to England for repairs.

The following day the Duke of York ordered a pursuit as the Dutch headed for home. The French, in the van, overtook the Dutch rear but unaccountably failed to engage and the pursuit was soon abandoned. Both sides had suffered heavy casualties, yet the moral victory clearly lay with the Dutch. Allied officers indulged in bitter recriminations, even between opposing factions within the national fleets, and the Comte d'Estrées' second-in-command Abraham Duquesne refused to serve under him again.

> "THE FIGHTING WAS SO STUBBORNLY CONTESTED BY BOTH SIDES THAT ONE COULD NOT COUNT EITHER SIDE AS HAVING THE ADVANTAGE..."
>
> **MARCUS GJOE**, DANISH OBSERVER, REPORTING ON THE BATTLE OF SOLEBAY





Royal Prince dismasted
English and Dutch sailors fight each other with oars, daggers, and cutlasses. In the background, Tromp's flagship *Gordon Leeuw* sails to the right of *Royal Prince*, Spragge's dismasted flagship.

THIRD ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

TEXEL



Date August 21, 1673
Forces English and French: 92 ships; Dutch: 75 ships
Losses none

Location Between Kamperduin and Texel

De Ruyter remained in his safe haven at Schooneveld until August 1673, when concerns for the safety of the incoming Dutch spice fleet made him sail north to the Texel and contest the Anglo-French blockade. As in the previous battles in this war, the tactical dexterity of the Dutch and the failure of coordination between different divisions of the allied fleet negated the Anglo-French numerical superiority.

The opposing rear divisions were commanded by Admiral Sir Edward Spragge and Lieutenant Admiral Cornelis Tromp. Spragge had developed a feud with Tromp and had given King Charles his word that he would kill the Dutch admiral. Pursuing his vendetta with no regard for the overall shape of the battle, he allowed his squadron to become detached from the center under Prince Rupert. Spragge and Tromp fought their personal duel with such ferocity that both had to shift their flags twice from corpse-strewn, dismasted ships. Transferring for the second time, Spragge was killed when a cannonball struck his boat.

Meanwhile, the French in the van became totally detached from the fight. De Ruyter initially sent a handful of ships under Adriaen Banckert to take on the Comte d'Estrées' division. At a chosen moment, Banckert disengaged and turned to join the battle in the center, where de Ruyter was engaged with Prince Rupert. Unable or unwilling to follow Banckert, the French were left with no one to fight. At the end of the day the Dutch disengaged and returned to safe anchorage. The allied naval command subsequently disintegrated in a storm of accusations of cowardice and treachery, focused chiefly upon the Comte d'Estrées' failure to come to Prince Rupert's aid.

WITNESS TO WAR

ENGLISH OFFICER, BLUE SQUADRON

IN A REPORT ON THE BATTLE AT THE BATTLE OF TEXEL

"I went aboard Sir Edward Spragge … and found his ship extremely disabled, and as we set our boat from his ship, ***down fell his main mast*** *within a yard of our boat … after this, Sir Edward Spragge came on board the St. George where* ***he put up his flag*** *… at two of the clock St. George was so disabled too that Sir Edward Spragge took boat to go on board the Royal Charles …* ***but a bullet came through the St. George and broke his boat****; they made back again as fast as they could … but the boat sunk, and* ***Sir Edward Spragge drowned*** *being taken up dead, his head and shoulders above water having taken so dead hold of the boat, they* ***could hardly disengage him from it****."*